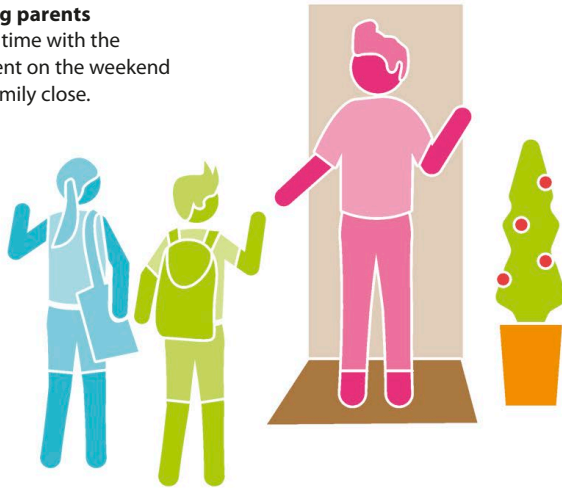


Separation and divorce

Most parents start their relationships full of hope for a long future together and a shared desire to build a strong and healthy family. Over time, relationships can change, and this may mean that parents feel that their only solution is to separate. How a teen copes is unique to the individual, but many hold on to a desire for their parents to stay together and to work out their problems.

▷ **Visiting parents**
Spending time with the other parent on the weekend keeps a family close.



PARENT TIPS

Supporting your teen

- Be clear about the fact that they are not a part of, or the reason for, the breakup, and that their relationship will continue with each parent.
- Refrain from sharing too much with your teen, or expecting them to handle information about your relationship.
- It's normal for teens to feel confused and angry when parents separate. Give them time to understand and adjust.
- Avoid complaining about your former partner, and don't expect your teen to take sides. Respect the fact that they need to maintain a positive relationship with the other parent.
- Expect difficult behavior and speak to your teen's school so they can inform you of any behavioral changes.
- Try to spend quality time with your teen, and with extended family, too. At the same time, be consistent with discipline and keep routines going.

Family illness and bereavement

The feelings that a person has when someone is sick, or after they have died, are often difficult to understand and deal with. Whether it be due to old age, long-term illness, or sudden death, losing a loved one is devastating, and no one can ever really be prepared. Everyone's experience of grief is unique, with different feelings and different ways of coping. It is important that everyone is given the space to talk (or not to talk) about what they are going through without pressure or judgment.



TEEN HINTS

Coping with bereavement

- Talking about your feelings can help you to organize your thinking and to understand the situation fully.
- Allow yourself to feel whatever it is that you are feeling. You might feel numb, disbelief, frustrated, angry, lonely, depressed, or anxious, and you may have regrets. It is normal to go through a range of emotions.
- Grief can be very tiring, so it's important to take care of yourself.
- Continue the hobbies and traditions that remind you of the person.
- Writing down how you feel can help you to express what the person meant to you.

◁ **Sharing memories**

Some people need to be with others when grieving. Other people prefer to be left alone.